It was exactly the sort of thing Israeli politicians routinely demand: a prominent figure in the Arab community, speaking out against incitement. So naturally the police arrested him. When he appeared in a Be’er Sheva court on Friday, the state argued that his words could be misunderstood, even if they were meant as satire. The judge, rather than dismiss the case, agreed with the state and extended his detention: he argued that Abudaabes should have considered how his post could be interpreted as “a call and encouragement to hurt the state”. It was a surreal scene when he returned a few days later for a bail hearing: the police admitted they’d made a mistake, and pleaded with the judge to release Abudaabes. He did—but ordered him to a brief period of house arrest, and a two-week ban from the internet.

Nearly a month later, only six people had been indicted, all of them for setting minor fires in northern Israel—not the major conflagrations in Haifa or outside Jerusalem. Most of the people arrested were released. Among them was Jawad Qattoush, the Palestinian from Battir whose face was aired on Channel 2 (and other networks). After five days of interrogation, the Shin Bet concluded that he had, in fact, started a fire. He burned some garbage on his own property, a mile away from any Jewish town. And then he extinguished it.